

3.2.2 Comparative politics

Students should use the following three theoretical approaches to make a comparative study of the government and politics of the UK and the USA, analysing and explaining similarities and differences between them.

- structural
- rational
- cultural.

3.2.2.1 Constitutional arrangements

Key concepts and terminology:

See [The nature and sources of the British Constitution](#) (page 10), [The structure and role of Parliament](#) (page 11) and [Devolution](#) (page 12) for key concepts and terminology relevant to UK constitutional arrangements.

See [The Constitutional framework of US government](#) (page 15), [The legislative branch of government: Congress](#) (page 16) and [The executive branch of government: President](#) (page 16) for key concepts and terminology relevant to US constitutional arrangements.

Focus

Students should analyse and evaluate:

- key similarities and differences between the UK and US constitutions and their impact on government and politics in their respective countries
- their nature(codified/uncodified), sources and provisions, separation of powers, checks and balances
- similarities and differences between the devolution model in the UK and the federal model in the USA
- the legislatures: their relative strengths and weaknesses and the extent to which their roles are similar and their powers equal
- powers, composition, structure, strengths and weaknesses.

3.2.2.2 The executives

Key concepts and terminology:

See [The Prime Minister and Cabinet](#) (page 11) for key concepts and terminology relevant to UK prime minister and cabinet.

See [The executive branch of government: President](#) (page 16) for key concepts and terminology relevant to the US executive branch of government.

Focus

Students should analyse and evaluate:

- the role and powers of the UK prime minister and of the US president, how they differ from each other and the extent of their accountability to the legislatures
- a comparison of the relationship of the UK prime minister and of the US president to other institutions of government.

3.2.2.3 The judiciaries

Key concepts and terminology:

See [The judiciary](#) (page 12) for key concepts and terminology relevant to the UK judiciary.

See [The judicial branch of government](#) (page 17) for key concepts and terminology relevant to the US judiciary.

Focus

Students should analyse and evaluate:

- similarities and differences of supreme courts
- impact on government and politics
- the relative extent of the powers of the UK Supreme Court and the US Supreme Court and the bases of those powers within their systems of government
- comparison of the relative independence of the judiciary in the UK and the USA.

3.2.2.4 Electoral and party systems

Key concepts and terminology:

See [Elections and referendums](#) (page 13) and [Political parties](#) (page 19) for key concepts and terminology relevant to UK electoral and party systems

See [The electoral process and direct democracy](#) (page 18) and [Political parties](#) (page 19) for key concepts and terminology relevant to US electoral and party systems

Focus

Students should analyse and evaluate:

- comparisons of elections and electoral systems used in the UK and USA
- comparisons of the two party systems and how they operate in the UK and the USA
- debates in the UK and USA surrounding campaign and party finance
- degrees of internal unity within the parties in the UK and the USA
- explanations of why the USA has a two party system whilst the UK is moving towards a multi-party system
- third party and independent candidates in the UK and the USA
- comparisons of party policies in the UK and the USA.

3.2.2.5 Pressure groups

Key concepts and terminology:

See [Pressure groups](#) (page 15) for key concepts and terminology relevant to the UK pressure groups

See [Pressure groups](#) (page 19) for key concepts and terminology relevant to US pressure groups

Focus

Students should analyse and evaluate:

- comparison of key similarities and differences of the influences on government in the UK and the USA
- the relative power, influence and methods of pressure groups in the UK and the USA.

3.2.2.6 Civil Rights

Key concepts and terminology:

See [The nature and sources of the British Constitution](#) (page 10) for key concepts and terminology relevant to UK civil rights.

See [Civil rights](#) (page 20) for key concepts and terminology relevant to US civil rights.

Focus

Students should analyse and evaluate:

- protection of civil rights key similarities and differences regarding the protection of civil rights in the UK and the USA
- debates about civil rights issues
- comparisons of methods, influence and effectiveness of civil rights campaigns in the UK and the USA.